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Smart conveyor belt service

Abstract

A smart conveyor belt web service is provided. A network device generates recipes for multiple orders. Each recipe provides sorting instructions for a conveyor system. The network device transfers an identifier for a first recipe to a queue of active recipes and sends the first recipe to a server device for the conveyor system. The network device receives a recipe-complete status message indicating completion of the first recipe. The network device deletes the indicator for the first recipe from the queue based on receiving the recipe-complete status message and transfers a second recipe to the queue of active recipes to initiate processing of another order.

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND

(1) Many merchants and vendors use shipping services to provide products to customers. Accurately packing boxes for customer shipments is an expensive process. Packing boxes for different combinations of products typically requires substantial human resources and can be prone to error. Some packing processes may be automated using a conveyor system. However, configuring a conveyor system to accommodate different types of customer orders remains a challenge.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) FIG. 1 is a diagram illustrating concepts described herein;
- (2) FIG. 2 is a diagram illustrating an example network environment in which a smart conveyor belt web service described herein may be implemented;
- (3) FIG. 3 is a diagram illustrating communications among example components of the smart conveyor belt web service;

- (4) FIGS. 4A-4C are examples of request and response formats that may be used in the smart conveyor belt web service;
- (5) FIG. 5 is a diagram illustrating example logical components of a Smart Conveyor as a Service (SCaaS) application client;
- (6) FIG. 6 is a flow diagram illustrating an example process for providing a smart conveyor belt web service, according to an implementation described herein; and
- (7) FIG. 7 is a diagram illustrating example components of a device that may correspond to one or more of the devices described herein.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF EXAMPLE EMBODIMENTS

(8) The following detailed description refers to the accompanying drawings. The same reference numbers in different drawings may identify the same or similar elements.

(9) Systems and methods described herein provide a service to allow for the dynamic sorting of items into respective bins around a conveyor belt system. Each bin represents and is used to fulfill an individual order, referred to herein as a “recipe.” Each recipe includes a complete list of all items belonging to an order. Recipes are queued and posted to the conveyor belt system as bins become available. Filled bins with completed orders are signaled for removal and replaced with empty bins that can accommodate new orders with dynamic assignment of new recipes. Thus, systems and methods described herein relate to continuous, dynamic sorting system for assembling heterogeneous orders.

(10) As described further herein, a smart conveyor belt management system includes a smart conveyor belt application (e.g., a service such as a web service, etc.) that uses an application server and an application client. Although some communications are described herein in the context of hypertext transfer protocol (HTTP) protocol, different protocols, such as HTTP Secure (HTTPS), may be used in other implementations. An HTTP server resides with the conveyor belt, and an HTTP client remains on a separate server for requesting and using the resources provided by the HTTP server. A REST API architecture may be leveraged in the smart conveyor belt service to make the interaction between the HTTP client and the HTTP server simple and stateless and may provide the interface between the two more uniform. Mechanical control of the conveyor belt and hardware components associated with the conveyor belt are managed by a conveyor belt control system, which may be associated with a vendor or customer that subscribes to the smart conveyor belt service. The management of the resources, such as recipes and alarms, is performed by the service application.

(11) According to an implementation, the application client resides on a service provider's network edge (e.g., a Radio Access Network (RAN) edge). The application client may receive multiple orders (e.g., customer orders), with each of the orders indicating one or more physical objects to be shipped to a customer. The application client may generate a separate recipe for each of the orders, with each of the recipes providing sorting instructions for a conveyor system. The application client may transfer an identifier (e.g., a unique order number or a different unique identifier) for a first recipe of the recipes to a queue of active recipes. The queue is configured to hold a number of entries up to the maximum capacity of the conveyor system (e.g., the number of sorting stations). The application client may send the first recipe to an application server for the conveyor system and separately provide an object list for the first recipe. The object list identifies physical objects to be placed on the conveyor system (e.g., by warehouse staff and/or an automated picking system). The application client may receive a “recipe-complete” status message indicating completion of the recipe by the conveyor system, and, in response, may delete the first recipe from the queue based on the message.

(12) Assuming a full queue, deletion of the first recipe may provide space in the queue of active recipes for another (e.g., second) recipe. In response to the deletion, the application client may transfer a second recipe to the queue, wherein the second recipe indicates one or more different physical objects than the first recipe. The application client may send the second recipe to the

application server, and separately send an object list that can be used to supply the physical objects for the second recipe.

(13) FIG. 1 illustrates concepts described herein. As shown in FIG. 1, conveyor system **100** may be managed by a service platform **170** to place objects **10** into boxes **20**. Each object **10** (e.g., a product to be shipped to a customer) may be labeled with a unique identifier, such as a barcode, QR code, or another machine-readable identifier (referred to herein as an “object bar code **15**”). Each box **20** (e.g., an individual shipping container) may also be labeled with a unique identifier (referred to herein as an “box bar code **25**”).

(14) Conveyor system **100** may include a conveyor belt **110**, multiple sorting stations **120**, a barcode reader **130**, diverters **140**, status monitors **150**, and a conveyor controller **160**. Objects **10** are placed on a feed area of conveyor belt **110**. Each of the sorting stations **120** may hold a box **20** for receiving objects in accordance with a specific recipe (e.g., corresponding to a customer order). Conveyor belt **110** moves objects **10** from the feed area past barcode reader **130** and multiple stations **120** toward a reject bin **30**. Barcode reader **130** may identify an object bar code **15** as the convey belt **110** carries an object **10** past barcode reader **130**. When a box **20** is placed within a sorting station **120**, diverters **140** can be selectively positioned to divert objects **10** from conveyor belt **110** into a desired box **20**.

(15) Status monitors **150** provide sensors and visual indicators to inform of conditions for each sorting station **120**. Status monitors **150** may include one or more sensors (e.g., pressure/weight sensors) and barcode readers that can identify when a box **20** is placed in a sorting station **120** and the barcode **25** of the respective box **20**. Status monitors **150** may provide information to conveyor controller **160**. The information may be used to assign recipes, track sorting progress, and identify errors. For example, for each sorting station **120**, status monitor **150** may indicate that a box is being filled in accordance with a recipe is in progress, that filling of a box according to a recipe is complete, that a sorting station is available, or an alarm/error condition has occurred. According to an implementation, status monitors **150** may also include indicators (e.g., colored lights) to provide a visual status for each sorting station **120**. For example, a green light may indicate a filling (of a box in accordance with a recipe) is complete, a yellow light may indicate a filling is in progress, a red light may indicate an alarm condition, and a no light may indicate the station is unassigned (e.g., no activity).

(16) Conveyor controller **160** may direct the mechanical operation of conveyor system **100** based on instructions from service platform **170**. Conveyor controller **160** may receive signals from barcode reader **130** and status monitors **150** to identify objects **10**/boxes **20** and to direct objects **10** into boxes **20** by controlling diverters **140** when objects move on conveyor belt **110**.

(17) Service platform **170** may include one or more computer or network devices to provide a smart conveyor belt web service. Although a single conveyor system **100** is shown in FIG. 1, service platform **170** may be located in a service provider's network and may be configured to provide services to multiple conveyor belt systems **100**. Service platform **170** may receive customer orders from ordering platform **180**. Service platform **170** may convert the customer orders to recipes that include, for example, specific item descriptions and barcode numbers/SKUs (stock keeping units). The recipes may also specify quantities (i.e., number of objects). Service platform **170** may provide the recipes to a worker or workstation as object listing **175**. Object listing **175** may include a physical or digital list to indicate to a worker what objects **10** need to be pulled from warehouse shelves and placed onto conveyor belt **110** for sorting. Service platform **170** may also provide the recipes to conveyor controller **160** to implement dynamic sorting.

(18) As described further herein, service platform **170** may use Smart Conveyor as a Service (SCaaS) application **199**, including an application client and an application server, to manage continuous, dynamic sorting of orders. Each application server may be associated with, for example, a single conveyor system **100** (e.g., integrated with conveyor controller **160**) or multiple conveyor systems **100** within a local area network (LAN). Service platform **170** may instantiate

multiple application clients to be serviced by different application servers (e.g., associated with different conveyor systems **100** and/or shipping customers).

(19) Ordering platform **180** may include a network device or computing device to obtain orders that require packaging and shipping. Ordering platform **180** may, for example, be part of a web-based platform for an online store or marketplace that receives order for physical products that must be shipped to buyers. Orders may include, for example, a combination of heterogeneous objects **10** that may be different for different orders.

(20) Warehouse management system **190** may include devices (e.g., networked computers) to track inventory, locate objects, and/or provide objects for sorting on conveyor systems **100**. According to an implementation, warehouse management system **190** may communicate with service platform **170** to track outgoing inventory (e.g., objects **20**). According to another implementation, warehouse management system **190** may include automated systems to provide objects to conveyor system **100**.

(21) In operation, a single sorting station **120**/box **20** may be assigned to each recipe by conveyor controller **160**. Based on signals from barcode reader **130**, conveyor controller **160** may identify objects **10** placed on conveyor belt **110** and direct the objects **10** for the recipe into a single box **20**. For example, conveyor controller **160** may assign a box **20** to a recipe when a first object **10** for the recipe is scanned by barcode reader **130**. A barcode **25** for the assigned box **20** may be associated with the recipe/order. Once all objects **10** for a recipe are sorted into the corresponding box **20**, the sorting process for that recipe is complete, at which point that box **20** can be identified as filled or complete and replaced in sorting station **120** with a new empty box **20** by a worker. With a new empty box **20** in sorting station **120**, the scanning and sorting of objects **10** for the next new recipe can commence to maintain a dynamic sorting operation.

(22) FIG. 2 is a diagram of an example network environment **200** in which a smart conveyor belt web service may be implemented. As shown in FIG. 2, environment **200** may include conveyor controller **160**, a radio access network (RAN) **220** that includes access devices **225**, multi-access edge computing (MEC) networks **240** that include MEC devices **245**, a core network **250** that includes network devices **255**, and data networks (DNs) **290-1** to **290-Y** (referred to herein collectively as “DNs **290**” and individually as “DN **290**”).

(23) Conveyor controller **160** may include a computing device or a communication device. Conveyor controller **160** may include, for example, a device with cellular wireless communication functionality. For example, conveyor controller **160** may be equipped with a cellular communications module (e.g., a data card) to enable conveyor controller **160** to communicate with access network **220**. In another implementation, conveyor controller **160** may include another communication module to enable indirect access to access network **220**, such as a wired or wireless interface to a hotspot device, a fixed wireless access device, and/or any other type of computer device with wireless communication capabilities. Conveyor controller **160** may be associated with a subscriber/account for using services of access network **220**, MEC network **240**, and/or core network **250**. Conveyor controller **160** may also include a processor and software (e.g., a SCaaS application server), as described further herein.

(24) Access network **220** may enable conveyor controller **160** to connect to core network **250** and/or MEC network **240** via access devices **225** using cellular wireless signals. Access device **225** may include a 5G New Radio (NR) base station (e.g., a gNodeB) and/or a Fourth Generation (4G) Long Term Evolution (LTE) base station (e.g., an eNodeB). Each access device **225** may include devices and/or components configured to enable cellular wireless communication with conveyor controller **160**. For example, access device **225** may include a radio frequency (RF) transceiver configured to communicate with UE devices using a 5G NR air interface, a 4G LTE air interface, and/or using another type of cellular air interface. Access device **225** may enable communication with core network **250** to enable core network **250** to authenticate and monitor network activity of conveyor controller **160**. According to one implementation, access network **220** may include a non-

standalone (NSA) network to support dual coverage using 4G and 5G networks. In another implementation, access network **220** may include a 5G standalone (SA) architecture.

(25) Each MEC network **240** may be associated with one or more access devices **225** and may provide MEC services for conveyor controllers **160** attached to the access devices **225**. MEC network **240** may be in proximity to the access devices **225** from a geographic and network topology perspective, thus enabling low latency communication with conveyor controller **160** and/or access devices **225**. As an example, MEC network **240** may be located on a same site as one of the access devices **225**. As another example, MEC network **240** may be geographically closer to the access devices **225** and reachable via fewer network hops and/or fewer switches than other access devices **225** and/or data networks **290**. MEC network **240** may include one or more MEC devices **245**. MEC devices **245** may provide MEC services to conveyor controller **160**, such as, for example, an SCaaS client application for service platform **170**.

(26) Core network **250** may be managed by a provider of cellular wireless communication services and may manage communication sessions of subscribers connecting to core network **250** via access network **220**. Core network **250** may include one or multiple networks of different types and technologies. For example, core network **250** may be implemented to include a next generation core (NGC) network for a 5G network, an Evolved Packet Core (EPC) of an LTE network, an LTE-A network, an LTE-A Pro network, another type of 4G core network, and/or a legacy core network.

(27) Core network **250** may include various network devices **255**. Depending on the implementation, network devices **255** may include 5G core network components (e.g., a User Plane Function (UPF), an Application Function (AF), an Access and Mobility Management Function (AMF), a Session Management Function (SMF), a Unified Data Management (UDM) function, a Network Slice Selection Function (NSSF), a Policy Control Function (PCF), a Unified Data Repository (UDR) etc.), 4G core network components (e.g., a Serving Gateway (SGW), a Packet Data Network Gateway (PGW), a Mobility Management Entity (MME), a Home Subscriber Server (HSS), etc.), or another type of core network components (e.g., future 6G network components). In other implementation, network devices **255** may include combined 4G and 5G functionality, such as a session management function with PDN gateway-control plane (SMF+PGW-C) and a user plane function with PDN gateway-user plane (UPF+PGW-U).

(28) Network device **255** may include a physical function node or a virtual network function (VNF). Thus, the components of core network **250** may be implemented as dedicated hardware components and/or as VNFs implemented on top of a commonly shared physical infrastructure using Software Defined Networking (SDN). The shared physical infrastructure may be implemented using one or more devices **700** described below with reference to FIG. 7 in a cloud computing center associated with core network **250**. Additionally, or alternatively, some, or all, of the shared physical infrastructure may be implemented using one or more devices **700** included in MEC device **245**.

(29) DNs **290** may each include a data network, such as a packet data network. A particular DN **290** may be associated with an Access Point Name (APN) and UE device **210** may request a connection to the particular packet data network **290** using the APN. DN **290** may include, and/or be connected to and enable communication with, a local area network (LAN), a wide area network (WAN), a metropolitan area network (MAN), an autonomous system (AS) on the Internet, an optical network, a cable television network, a satellite network, a wireless network (e.g., a CDMA network, a general packet radio service (GPRS) network, and/or an LTE network), an ad hoc network, a telephone network (e.g., the Public Switched Telephone Network (PSTN) or a cellular network), an intranet, or a combination of networks.

(30) Although FIG. 2 shows example components of environment **200**, in other implementations, environment **200** may include fewer components, different components, differently arranged components, or additional components than depicted in FIG. 2. Additionally, or alternatively, one or more components of environment **200** may perform functions described as being performed by

one or more other components of environment **200**.

(31) FIG. 3 is a diagram illustrating functions and communications of SCaaS application **199** in a portion **300** of network **200**. As shown in the example of FIG. 3, SCaaS application **199** may be implemented as an application client **310** (e.g., an HTTP client) and an application server **320** (e.g., an HTTP server). Application server **320** may be included on location with conveyor system **100** (e.g., executed on or in communication with conveyor controller **160**). Application client **310** may be executed within a service provider network, such as MEC network **240**, core network **250**, or data network **290**. A REST API architecture may be leveraged to make the interaction between SCaaS application **199** and controller **160** simple and stateless, and the interface between the two more uniform.

(32) Conveyor controller **160** may manage the mechanical control of conveyor system **100** and the associated hardware components. Management of the software resources, such as recipes and alarms described herein remain with SCaaS application **199**. Controller **160** may receive and process recipes from server **320**. Controller **160** may perform scans of objects **10** (e.g., barcodes **15**) and boxes (e.g., barcodes **25**). Controller **160** may direct sorting of objects **10** from conveyor belt **110** into boxes **20** based on the scans and the recipes. Controller **160** may report alarms and status reports to server **320**.

(33) Ordering platform **180** may obtain orders that require packaging and shipping. Orders may include, for example, a list of objects **10** (e.g., a collection of identifiers for the objects **10**). Ordering platform **180** may provide orders to SCaaS application **199** (e.g., application client **310**) affiliated with ordering platform **180**.

(34) Application client **310** may receive orders posted from ordering platform(s) **180** and create a recipe for each order. A recipe may include a list of individual components for an order. In some implementations, the recipe may also include a preferred size for box **20** (e.g., a box with certain dimensions for holding the collection of items in the recipe). That is, application client **310** may calculate required box dimensions based on the recipe and select a smallest box size (e.g., of standard box sizes available to conveyor system **100**) that meets the required box dimensions. Application client **310** may queue recipes for submission to server **320**/controller **160**. Application client **310** may also respond to alarms and/or status reports received from server **320**. According to an implementation, application client **310** may be instantiated in a MEC device **245** (e.g., with geographic proximity to application server **320** and/or an access device **225** servicing application server **320**). Application client **310** is described further in connection with FIG. 4.

(35) Application server **320** may receive recipes from application client **310** and may post the queued recipes to controller **160**. Server **320** may receive alarms and status reports from controller **160**, queue the alarms and/or status reports, and forward the alarms and status reports to application client **310**. According to an implementation, server **320** may be included with or physically connected to controller **160**. According to an implementation, server **320** may issue API calls to controller **160** for the smart conveyor belt web service. According to an implementation, the APIs may include REST APIs for application **199** to provide instructions to controller **160** to: post a new recipe, get a list of active recipes, get a list of unmatched items, get a list of completed recipes, delete a specific (e.g., active or completed) recipe, post a delete requests to delete all active and completed recipes, get a list of all active alarms, delete a specific alarm, post a delete all (e.g., outstanding and active) alarms, and get a system health status.

(36) In operation, ordering platform **180** may obtain orders that require packing and shipping of objects **10**. Orders may include, for example, same or different set of objects **10**. Ordering system may send orders **332** to application **199**. For example, ordering platform **180** may establish a communication session with application client **310** and provide an HTTP Post message with an order to application client **310**. Application client **310** may receive orders **332** and may generate a recipe **334** for each order. Each recipe **334** may be placed in a queue that is managed by application client **310**. Application client **310** may release recipes **334** for fulfilment in accordance with the

number of sorting stations **120** available in conveyor system **100**. For example, if conveyor belt system **110** has ten stations **120**, each with a box **20**, application client **310** may provide up to 10 active recipes to server **320** and enqueue any other recipes that exceed the current capacity of the conveyor system **100**.

(37) Along with sending an active recipe to server **320**, application client **310** may also send an object list **336** to object listing **175**. Object list **336** may be used (e.g., by warehouse personnel or automated systems) to retrieve objects **10** from warehouse shelves and place the retrieved objects on conveyor belt **110** for sorting. According to an implementation, object list **336** may include a copy of recipe **334**. In another implementation, server **320** may extract an object list **336** from a recipe **334** for presentation to object listing **175**.

(38) Application server **320** may receive recipes **334** and may post recipes **338** to controller **160**. FIG. **4A** illustrates an example of a post recipe message **410** that may be sent from application server **320** to controller **160**. As illustrated in FIG. **4A**, each post recipe message **410** may include a unique “reference” ID (e.g., corresponding to an order number) and a list of objects. Each object listed in a recipe may also have a unique ID (e.g., corresponding to an SKU), a quantity, and a specification/description. As part of an exchange for posting recipes **338**, controller **160** may provide one of several possible HTTP responses, including for example: **201** (CREATE)—Standard response for a recipe being successfully posted. **400** (BAD REQUEST)—The request cannot be processed because of bad request syntax, excessive size, or another client error. **404** (NOT FOUND)—The resource could not be found at this time. It is possible it was deleted, or does not exist yet. **500** (INTERNAL SERVER ERROR)—A generic answer for an unexpected failure if there is no more specific information available. Assuming a success recipe posting **338**, controller **160** may sort objects **10** (e.g., objects placed onto conveyor belt **110**) into boxes **20**, according to instructions post recipe message **410**.

(39) As indicated by reference **340**, application server **320** may request alarms and recipe status from controller **160**. For example, application server **320** may provide HTTP GET messages (e.g., at regular polling intervals) to request an active recipe status, a listing of all active recipes with controller **160**, alarm reports, etc. FIG. **4B** illustrates an example of a status message **420** that may be sent from controller **160** to application server **320** in response to a request to get a list of active recipes. As illustrated in FIG. **4B**, status message **420** may include a list of active recipes with their “reference” IDs and list of items with their unique IDs or an empty list. In FIG. **4B**, the active list of recipes includes a single recipe for simplicity. FIG. **4C** illustrates an example of a status message **430** that may be sent from controller **160** to application server **320** in response to a request to get a list of completed recipes. As illustrated in FIG. **4C**, status message **430** may include a list of active recipes with their “reference” IDs and list of items with their unique IDs or an empty list. In the illustration of FIG. **4C**, the active list of recipes includes a single recipe for simplicity. The “specification” field in message **430** may be used to list all of barcodes (e.g., object barcodes **25**) that were detected while scanning an object **20**. As described further herein, the completed recipes indicated in status message **430** may be explicitly requested to be deleted from the active queue by the application client **310**.

(40) Server **320** may provide alarm and recipe status information **342** to application client **310**. As described further below, application client **310** may apply the status/alarm information to manage queues and direct completion of recipes/orders by conveyor system **100**. Application client **310** may also receive requests **344** from ordering platform **180** and provide status reports and/or alarm status to ordering platform **180**, based on the alarm and recipe status information **342**.

(41) Communications shown in FIG. **3** provide simplified illustrations of communications in network portion **300** and are not intended to reflect every signal or communication exchanged between devices/functions. For example, in other implementations a subscription-notification model may be used instead of a request-response model.

(42) FIG. **5** is a block diagram illustrating logical components of application client **310** to

implement the smart conveyor belt web service. As shown in FIG. 5, application client **310** may include a recipe generator **510**, a received recipe queue **520**, an active recipe queue **530**, and queue management logic **540**. The components of FIG. 5 may be implemented, for example, by processor (e.g., processor **710** described in connection with FIG. 7) in conjunction with memory (e.g., memory **715** of FIG. 7).

(43) Recipe generator **510** may receive orders (e.g., from order platform **180**) and dynamically generate individual recipes for each order. Customer orders may include a unique order number (e.g., an alphanumeric code) and identifiers for multiple objects, with one or more quantity per object. According to an implementation, order **510** may include all the information required to form a recipe, and recipe generator **510** may extract and reformat information in the order into a format useable by conveyor system **100**. According to another implementation, recipe generator **510** may communicate with an inventory system (e.g., warehouse management system **190**) to collect additional information to generate a recipe. Each object may have a corresponding barcode that is recorded in a warehouse inventory system and used for labeling the packaging for the object.

Recipe generator **510** may convert an order into a recipe format, such as: <ORDER #> <object_1-description>:<barcode>:<quantity> <object_2-description>:<barcode>:<quantity>

As a non-limiting example, an order with a designated order number “123xyz” could include a smart phone, a smartphone case, ear buds, and two screen protectors. Recipe generator **510** may convert this order into a recipe, such as: <ORDER 123xyz> <Apple_12s_128 GB>:<15489653-1>:<1> <Kensington_12s_case_red>:<6586974>:<1> <Pods_2.0>:<55261734-1>:<1> <Blipo_Screen_12s>:<55261734-1>:<2>

In other implementations, the recipe may include additional or different information. For example, the recipe may additionally include warehouse location (e.g., an aisle and shelf identifier, etc.) for each object. In still another implementation, recipe generator **510** may identify a box/container for a corresponding order. For example, assuming an inventory system can supply sizes/dimensions for each object, recipe generator **510** may be configured to select a size, from multiple box sizes, that is optimal for the group of objects for the corresponding recipe.

(44) Received recipe queue **520** may include a dynamic list of recipes (e.g., pending recipes) output by recipe generator **510**. The size of received recipe queue **520** may be larger than active recipe queue **530**, as received recipe queue **520** is not limited by the configuration of conveyor system **100**. That is, received recipe queue **520** may include, for example, a place holder (e.g., order number) for each recipe that has not yet been assigned to active recipe queue **530** to be processed by conveyor controller **160**.

(45) Active recipe queue **530** may include a list of recipes that have been provided to conveyor controller **160** for processing. The number of entries for active recipe queue **530** would be limited to the number of sorting stations **120** in conveyor system **100**. The number of entries for active recipe queue **530** may be further limited if one or more sorting stations **120** do not currently have a box **20** or are otherwise indicated to be inoperable.

(46) Queue management logic **540** may include logic to coordinate recipes to be processed by conveyor system **100**. After recipes are placed in received recipe queue **520**, queue management logic **540** may monitor active recipe queue **530** for availability (e.g., monitor for an empty slot or entry). Assuming active recipe queue **530** is not full, queue management logic **540** may select the oldest recipe from received recipe queue **520**, send the selected recipe to server **320**, send a copy of the selected recipe (e.g., an order list) to object listing **175**, and transfer the selected recipe from received recipe queue **520** to active recipe queue **530**.

(47) Queue management logic **540** may receive status reports from conveyor controller **160** (e.g., via server **320**). Status reports (e.g., corresponding to alarms and status **340**) may include a “bin assigned” message, a “recipe complete” message, and a “bin available” message. The “bin assigned” message may be provided to queue management logic **540** when conveyor system **100** assigns a first object in a recipe to a box **20**/sorting station **120**. The “bin assigned” message may

include a sorting station identifier and/or a corresponding box barcode **25** for the box in that sorting station. A “recipe complete” message may be provided to queue management logic **540** when conveyor system **100** detects that all objects **10** for a recipe have been sorted into a box **20** and the box **20** has been removed from the corresponding sorting station **120**. Upon receiving a “recipe complete” status, queue management logic **540** may delete the recipe placeholder and corresponding queue slot from the active recipe queue **530**. The “bin available” message may be provided to queue management logic **540** when conveyor system **100** detects that a new box **20** is placed in a sorting station **120** (e.g., upon removing a completed recipe). The “bin available” message may indicate to queue management logic **540** that a queue slot may be made available in active recipe queue **530**.

(48) Although FIG. 5 shows exemplary logical components of application client **310**, in other implementations, application client **310** may include fewer components, different components, or additional components than depicted in FIG. 5. Additionally, or alternatively, one or more components of application client **310** may be included in another network element. For example, active recipe queue **530** may be stored in server **320** in another implementation.

(49) FIG. 6 illustrates a logical flow of SCaaS application **199**, according to an implementation. Application client **310** may receive an order (block **605**), create a recipe (block **610**), add the recipe to a receive queue (block **615**), and determine if an active recipe queue is full (block **620**). For example, recipe generator **510** may receive an order from order platform **180** and dynamically generate an individual recipe. Recipe generator **510** may add a place holder for the recipe to received recipe queue **520**. The number of recipes in active recipe queue **530** may be limited to the number of functional sorting stations **120** with boxes **20** in conveyor system **100**. Queue management logic **540** may monitor active recipe queue **530** to determine if recipes from received recipe queue **520** can be transferred to active recipe queue **530**.

(50) If the active recipe queue is not full (block **620**—No), application client **310** may transfer a recipe to the active queue (block **625**), send the recipe and object listing (block **630**). For example, queue management logic **540** may identify one or more open slots in active recipe queue **530**. Queue management logic **540** may transfer the selected recipe from received recipe queue **520** to active recipe queue **530**. Queue management logic **540** may select/de-queue the oldest recipe from received recipe queue **520** and send the selected recipe to server **320**. Queue management logic **540** may also send a copy of the selected recipe (e.g., object list **336**) to object listing **175**. In another implementation, object list **336** may be extracted from a recipe **334** by server **320** for presentation as object listing **175**.

(51) Application client **310** may monitor status reports for a station assignment (block **635**). If a sorting station assignment is received (block **635**—Yes), the active queue may be updated (block **640**). For example, application client **310** may receive a status report from controller **160** (e.g., via server **320**) to indicate that a first object **10** for a recipe has been assigned to a specific sorting station **120** and box **20**. The status report may enable application client **310** to associate an order number with a box number for the recipe. Queue management logic **540** may associate in active queue **530** the customer order number with the identifier **25** for box **20**.

(52) Application client **310** may monitor status reports for a completion message (block **645**). If a recipe complete message is received (block **645**—Yes), a delete notification may be provided (block **650**), and the active queue may be updated (block **655**). For example, application client **310** may receive a status report from controller **160** (e.g., via server **320**) to indicate that conveyor system **100** has completed the recipe. According to an implementation, a completed recipe status message may be provided when all objects for the recipe are sorted to a box **20** and the box **20** is removed from sorting station **120**. Once a completed recipe status is received by application client **310**, application client **310** can then send a DELETE request to server **320**/controller **160** for the completed recipe. Additionally, application client **310** may delete the recipe from active recipe queue **530**. According to another implementation, application client **310** may also send a record to

another entity, such as warehouse management system **190**, for further tracking of the order (e.g., via the associated box identifier). According to another implementation, SCaaS application **199** may also send to a warehouse management system **190** an inventory update message based on the completed recipe status. The inventory update message may include, for example, object barcodes and other data from status message **430**.

(53) After deleting the recipe from the active queue **530**, application client **310** may return to block **620** to add another recipe to the active queue, if necessary. For example, application client **310** may send to server **320** a POST request for a new recipe, if another recipe is available in received queue **520** to be processed.

(54) If a sorting station assignment is not received (block **635**—NO), or if a recipe complete message is not received (block **645**—No), application client **310** may generate an alarm message (block **660**). For example, if application client **310** does not receive a status message with a sorting station assignment for a recipe within a predetermined interval (e.g., three minutes, five minutes, ten minutes, etc.), application client **310** may issue an alarm which may include issuing a notification message to an operator and/or triggering an LED indicator on conveyor system.

(55) FIG. 7 is a diagram illustrating example components of a device **700** that may be included in one or more of the devices described herein. For example, device **700** may correspond to conveyor controller **160**, service platform **170**, ordering platform **180**, warehouse management system **190**, and/or other types of devices, as described herein. As illustrated in FIG. 7, device **700** includes a bus **705**, a processor **710**, a memory/storage **715** that stores software **720**, a communication interface **725**, an input **730**, and an output **735**. According to other embodiments, device **700** may include fewer components, additional components, different components, and/or a different arrangement of components than those illustrated in FIG. 7 and described herein.

(56) Bus **705** includes a path that permits communication among the components of device **700**. For example, bus **705** may include a system bus, an address bus, a data bus, and/or a control bus. Bus **705** may also include bus drivers, bus arbiters, bus interfaces, clocks, and so forth.

(57) Processor **710** includes one or multiple processors, microprocessors, data processors, co-processors, graphics processing units (GPUs), application specific integrated circuits (ASICs), controllers, programmable logic devices, chipsets, field-programmable gate arrays (FPGAs), application specific instruction-set processors (ASIPs), system-on-chips (SoCs), central processing units (CPUs) (e.g., one or multiple cores), microcontrollers, neural processing unit (NPU), and/or some other type of component that interprets and/or executes instructions and/or data. Processor **710** may be implemented as hardware (e.g., a microprocessor, etc.), a combination of hardware and software (e.g., a SoC, an ASIC, etc.), may include one or multiple memories (e.g., cache, etc.), etc.

(58) Processor **710** may control the overall operation, or a portion of operation(s) performed by device **700**. Processor **710** may perform one or multiple operations based on an operating system and/or various applications or computer programs (e.g., software **720**). Processor **710** may access instructions from memory/storage **715**, from other components of device **700**, and/or from a source external to device **700** (e.g., a network, another device, etc.). Processor **710** may perform an operation and/or a process based on various techniques including, for example, multithreading, parallel processing, pipelining, interleaving, learning, model-based, etc.

(59) Memory/storage **715** includes one or multiple memories and/or one or multiple other types of storage mediums. For example, memory/storage **715** may include one or multiple types of memories, such as, a random access memory (RAM), a dynamic random access memory (DRAM), a static random access memory (SRAM), a cache, a read only memory (ROM), a programmable read only memory (PROM), an erasable PROM (EPROM), an electrically EPROM (EEPROM), a single in-line memory module (SIMM), a dual in-line memory module (DIMM), a flash memory (e.g., 2D, 3D, NOR, NAND, etc.), a solid state memory, and/or some other type of memory. Memory/storage **715** may include a hard disk (e.g., a magnetic disk, an optical disk, a magneto-optic disk, a solid state disk, etc.), a Micro-Electromechanical System (MEMS)-based storage

medium, and/or a nanotechnology-based storage medium. Memory/storage **715** may include drives for reading from and writing to the storage medium.

(60) Memory/storage **715** may be external to and/or removable from device **700**, such as, for example, a Universal Serial Bus (USB) memory stick, a dongle, a hard disk, mass storage, off-line storage, or some other type of storing medium. Memory/storage **715** may store data, software, and/or instructions related to the operation of device **700**.

(61) Software **720** includes an application or a program that provides a function and/or a process. As an example, with reference to service platform **170**, software **720** may include an application that, when executed by processor **710**, provides a function and/or a process of the smart conveyor belt web service platform, as described herein. Software **720** may also include firmware, middleware, microcode, hardware description language (HDL), and/or other form of instruction. Software **720** may also be virtualized. Software **720** may further include an operating system (OS) (e.g., Windows, Linux, Android, proprietary, etc.).

(62) Communication interface **725** permits device **700** to communicate with other devices, networks, systems, and/or the like. Communication interface **725** includes one or multiple wireless interfaces and/or wired interfaces. For example, communication interface **725** may include one or multiple transmitters and receivers, or transceivers. Communication interface **725** may operate according to a protocol stack and a communication standard. Communication interface **725** may include an antenna. Communication interface **725** may include various processing logic or circuitry (e.g., multiplexing/de-multiplexing, filtering, amplifying, converting, error correction, application programming interface (API), etc.). Communication interface **725** may be implemented as a point-to-point interface, a service-based interface, or a reference interface, for example.

(63) Input **730** permits an input into device **700**. For example, input **730** may include a keyboard, a mouse, a display, a touchscreen, a touchless screen, a button, a switch, an input port, a joystick, speech recognition logic, and/or some other type of visual, auditory, tactile, affective, olfactory, etc., input component. Output **735** permits an output from device **700**. For example, output **735** may include a speaker, a display, a touchscreen, a touchless screen, a light, an output port, and/or some other type of visual, auditory, tactile, etc., output component.

(64) As previously described, a network device may be implemented according to various computing architectures (e.g., in a cloud, etc.) and according to various network architectures (e.g., a virtualized function, etc.). Device **700** may be implemented in the same manner. For example, device **700** may be instantiated, created, deleted, or some other operational state during its life-cycle (e.g., refreshed, paused, suspended, rebooting, or another type of state or status), using well-known virtualization technologies (e.g., hypervisor, container engine, virtual container, virtual machine, etc.) in an application service layer network (e.g., data network **290**) and/or another type of network (e.g., access network **220**, core network **250**, etc.). Thus, network devices described herein may be implemented as device **700**.

(65) Device **700** may perform a process and/or a function, as described herein, in response to processor **710** executing software **720** stored by memory/storage **715**. By way of example, instructions may be read into memory/storage **715** from another memory/storage **715** (not shown) or read from another device (not shown) via communication interface **725**. The instructions stored by memory/storage **715** may cause processor **710** to perform a function or a process described herein. Alternatively, for example, according to other implementations, device **700** performs a function or a process described herein based on the execution of hardware (processor **710**, etc.).

(66) The foregoing description of implementations provides illustration and description, but is not intended to be exhaustive or to limit the invention to the precise form disclosed. Modifications and variations are possible in light of the above teachings or may be acquired from practice of the invention. For example, while a series of blocks have been described with regard to FIG. **6**, and message flows with respect to FIG. **3**, the order of the blocks and message flows may be modified in other embodiments. Further, non-dependent blocks may be performed in parallel.

- (67) Certain features described above may be implemented as “logic” or a “unit” that performs one or more functions. This logic or unit may include hardware, such as one or more processors, microprocessors, application specific integrated circuits, or field programmable gate arrays, software, or a combination of hardware and software.
- (68) To the extent the aforementioned embodiments collect, store or employ personal information provided by individuals, it should be understood that such information shall be used in accordance with all applicable laws concerning protection of personal information. Additionally, the collection, storage and use of such information may be subject to consent of the individual to such activity, for example, through well known “opt-in” or “opt-out” processes as may be appropriate for the situation and type of information. Storage and use of personal information may be in an appropriately secure manner reflective of the type of information, for example, through various encryption and anonymization techniques for particularly sensitive information.
- (69) Use of ordinal terms such as “first,” “second,” “third,” etc., in the claims to modify a claim element does not by itself connote any priority, precedence, or order of one claim element over another, the temporal order in which acts of a method are performed, the temporal order in which instructions executed by a device are performed, etc., but are used merely as labels to distinguish one claim element having a certain name from another element having a same name (but for use of the ordinal term) to distinguish the claim elements.
- (70) No element, act, or instruction used in the description of the present application should be construed as critical or essential to the invention unless explicitly described as such. Also, as used herein, the article “a” is intended to include one or more items. Further, the phrase “based on” is intended to mean “based, at least in part, on” unless explicitly stated otherwise.
- (71) In the preceding specification, various preferred embodiments have been described with reference to the accompanying drawings. It will, however, be evident that various modifications and changes may be made thereto, and additional embodiments may be implemented, without departing from the broader scope of the invention as set forth in the claims that follow. The specification and drawings are accordingly to be regarded in an illustrative rather than restrictive sense.

Claims

1. A method, comprising: receiving, by network device, multiple orders, wherein each of the orders indicates one or more physical objects to be shipped; generating, by network device, recipes for each of the multiple orders, wherein each of the recipes provides sorting instructions for a conveyor system; transferring, by the network device, an identifier for a first recipe of the recipes to a queue of active recipes, wherein the queue is configured to hold a number of entries that is less than or equal to a number of sorting stations in the conveyor system; sending, by the network device, the first recipe to a server device for the conveyor system; receiving, by the network device, a recipe-complete status message indicating completion of the first recipe; deleting, by the network device, the identifier for the first recipe from the queue based on receiving the recipe-complete status message; transferring, by the network device, a second recipe of the recipes to the queue of active recipes, wherein the second recipe indicates one or more different physical objects than the first recipe; and sending, by the network device, the second recipe to the conveyor system.
2. The method of claim 1, further comprising: adding, by the network device and prior to the transferring the identifier for the first recipe, each of the recipes to a queue of pending recipes, wherein the queue of pending recipes is configured to hold a number of entries that is greater than the number of sorting stations in the conveyor system.
3. The method of claim 1, further comprising: sending, by the network device, an object list for the first recipe, wherein the object list identifies physical objects to be provided to the conveyor system; and sending, by the network device, another object list for the second recipe, wherein the

other object list identifies different physical objects to be provided to the conveyor system.

4. The method of claim 1, further comprising: initiating, by the network device, a communication session with the server device, wherein the server device executes a server application for the conveyor system.

5. The method of claim 1, wherein the identifier of each of the recipes is a unique identifier and each of the recipes include a list of objects for the order.

6. The method of claim 1, wherein the network device is included within a Multi-access Edge Computing (MEC) platform, and wherein the server device is included within a local area network (LAN) for the conveyor system.

7. The method of claim 1, further comprising: receiving, by the network device, a bin-assigned status message associating the first recipe with a box identifier in the conveyor system, wherein the bin-assigned status message originates from the conveyor system after a first physical object for the first recipe has been scanned by the conveyor system.

8. The method of claim 7, further comprising: updating, by the network device and based on the bin-assigned status message, the queue of active recipes to associate the box identifier with the recipe identifier.

9. The method of claim 1, wherein the recipe-complete status message originates from the conveyor system, wherein the recipe-complete status message further indicates removal of box from the sorting station.

10. The method of claim 1, further comprising: sending, by the network device and to a warehouse management system, an inventory update message based on the recipe-complete status message.

11. A system comprising: a network device including a processor configured to: receive multiple orders, wherein each of the orders indicates one or more physical objects to be shipped; generate recipes for each of the multiple orders, wherein each of the recipes provides sorting instructions for a conveyor system; transfer an identifier for a first recipe of the recipes to a queue of active recipes, wherein the queue is configured to hold a number of entries that is less than or equal to a number of sorting stations in the conveyor system; send the first recipe to a server device for the conveyor system; receive a recipe-complete status message indicating completion of the first recipe; delete the identifier for the first recipe from the queue based on receiving the recipe-complete status message; transfer a second recipe of the recipes to the queue of active recipes, wherein the second recipe indicates one or more different physical objects than the first recipe; and send the second recipe to the conveyor system.

12. The system of claim 11, wherein the processor is further configured to: add, prior to the transferring the identifier for the first recipe, each of the recipes to a queue of pending recipes, wherein the queue of pending recipes is configured to hold a number of entries that is greater than the number of sorting stations in the conveyor system.

13. The system of claim 11, wherein the processor is further configured to: send an object list for the first recipe, wherein the object list identifies physical objects to be placed on the conveyor system, and send another object list for the second recipe, wherein the other object list identifies different physical objects to be placed on the conveyor system.

14. The system of claim 11, wherein the processor is further configured to: initiate a communication session with the server device, wherein the server device executes a server application for the conveyor system.

15. The system of claim 11, wherein the identifier of each of the recipes is a unique identifier and each of the recipes include a list of objects for the order.

16. The system of claim 11, wherein the network device is included within a Multi-access Edge Computing (MEC) platform.

17. The system of claim 11, wherein the processor is further configured to: receive a bin-assigned status message associating the first recipe with a box identifier in the conveyor system, wherein the bin-assigned status message originates from the conveyor system after a first physical object for the

first recipe has been scanned by the conveyor system.

18. A non-transitory computer-readable medium containing instructions, executable by at least one processor of a network device, for: receiving, by network device, multiple orders, wherein each of the orders indicates one or more physical objects to be shipped; generating, by network device, recipes for each of the multiple orders, wherein each of the recipes provides sorting instructions for a conveyor system; transferring, by the network device, an identifier for a first recipe of the recipes to a queue of active recipes, wherein the queue is configured to hold a number of entries that is less than or equal to a number of sorting stations in the conveyor system; sending, by the network device, the first recipe to a server device for the conveyor system; receiving, by the network device, a recipe-complete status message indicating completion of the first recipe; deleting, by the network device, the identifier for the first recipe from the queue based on receiving the recipe-complete status message; transferring, by the network device, a second recipe of the recipes to the queue of active recipes, wherein the second recipe indicates one or more different physical objects than the first recipe; and sending, by the network device, the second recipe to the conveyor system.

19. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 18, further comprising instructions for: receiving, by the network device, a bin-assigned status message associating the first recipe with a box identifier in the conveyor system, wherein the bin-assigned status message originates from the conveyor system after a first physical object for the first recipe has been scanned by the conveyor system.

20. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 18, wherein the recipe-complete status message originates from the conveyor system in response to a polling message, and wherein the recipe-complete status message further indicates removal of box from the sorting station.
